

Everyone's soul is burning

Metaphorical and Somatic Expressions of Heat in Russian-language Diaries



Viktoria Vorobeva
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1. Introduction

This poster explores how diarists use the language of heat to articulate their inner lives. Analyzing personal writings across different historical periods allows us to trace how the underlying emotions driving these heat expressions may shift over time.

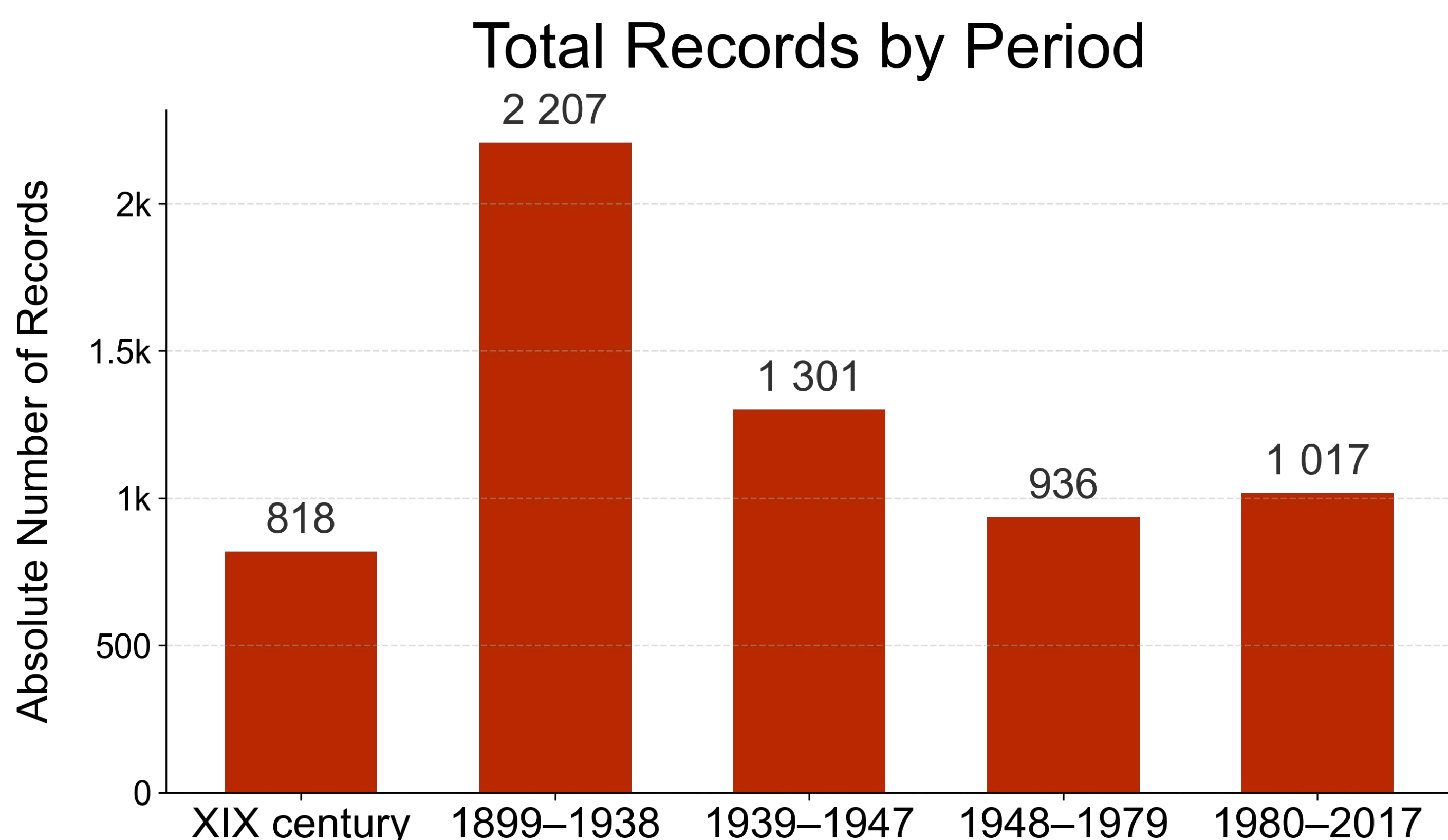


Figure 1. Total volume of records from the Prozhito database per historical period.

3. Key Insights

The Stability of Passionate Metaphors. Abstract metaphors and figurative expressions appear more frequently than actual somatic descriptions. Across almost all periods, metaphors tend to lean toward high-arousal, predominantly positive states, such as romantic love and creative excitement.

Dramatic Events Reshaping the Language of Heat. During the wartime period (1939–1947), metaphorical anger emerges as a prominent new category. This suggests that during dramatic historical events, heat metaphors can be repurposed to express political and social rage. Furthermore, the political context surges to become the dominant semantic framework of this era.

Somatic Heat as a Stress Response. In times of relative stability, physical feverishness is often split between describing love and anxiety. However, during the turbulent first half of the 20th century, “somatic romance” becomes less visible. Instead, physical heat appears to function as a language of discomfort.

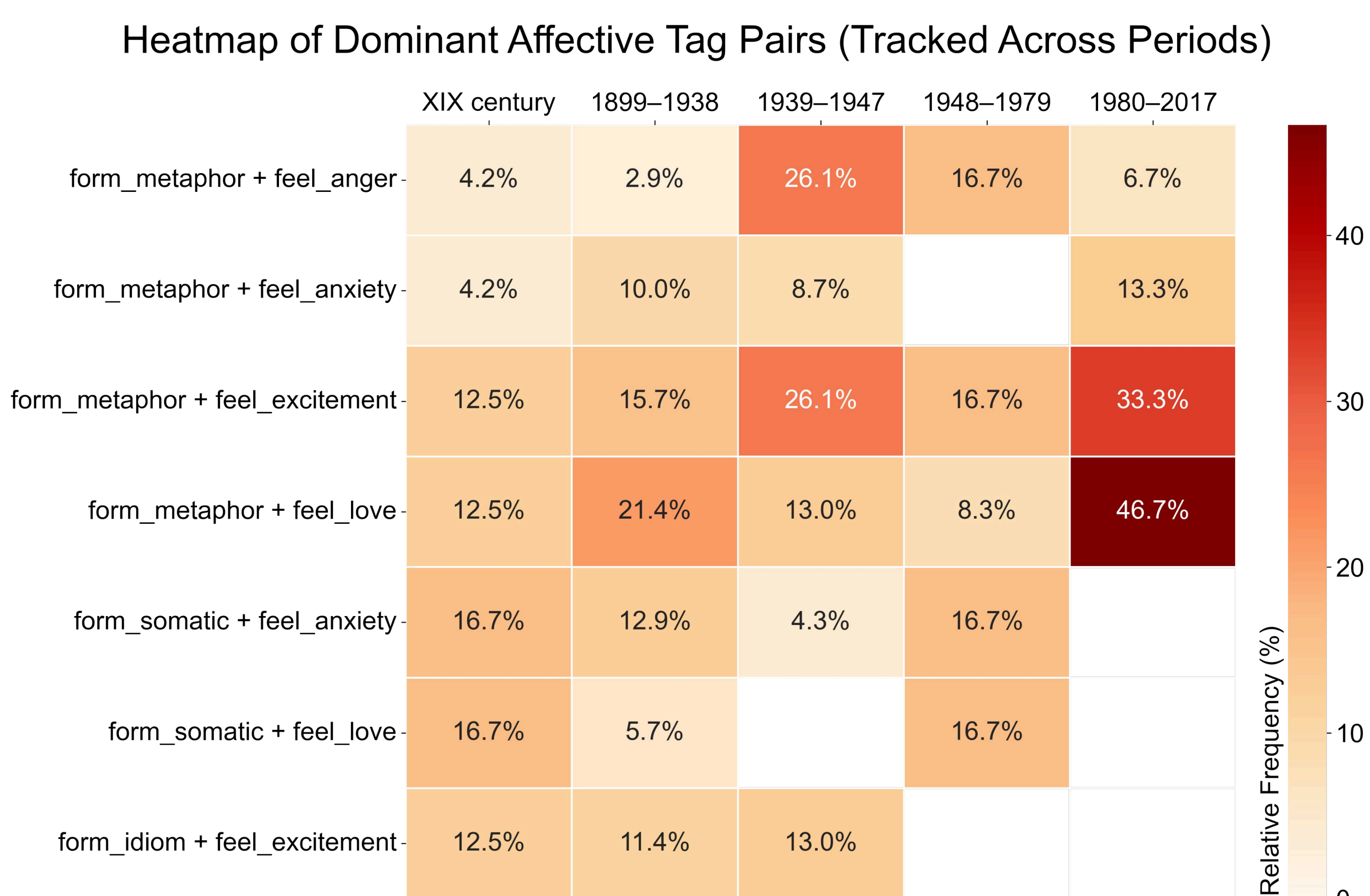


Figure 2. Relative frequency of the dominant form and emotion tag pairs across historical periods.

2. Data & Methodology

This analysis utilizes the Prozhito database, a large-scale corpus of digitized diaries from the Russian Empire through modern Russia.

Extraction. Regular expressions were utilized to isolate records connected to the feeling of heat, filtering out literal descriptions of weather or physical illness.

Annotation. This targeted filtering produced a concentrated dataset of 301 records. Each record was manually annotated using a custom taxonomy:

- Linguistic Form (e.g., poetic metaphor, somatic reaction, idiom)
- Emotional State (e.g., love, anxiety, excitement, anger, shame)
- Context (e.g., politics, religion, creation, interpersonal)

Data Distribution. The final annotated dataset comprises 210 relevant records. The chronological distribution is uneven, containing 32 records from the XIX century, 91 from 1899–1938, 36 from 1939–1947, 24 from 1948–1979, and 27 from 1980–2017. This temporal imbalance reflects the heterogeneous nature of the underlying Prozhito database.

4. Diary Quotes

- Heat as Romantic Passion:** “Oh, if only she loved me the way I love her! She would feel that thirst for a meeting with her with which I burn.” — *Vladimir Sitnikov, 1926*
- Heat as Political Stress:** “This obviously means relocation is near. I, of course, got very upset, it even became hot in my heart.” — *Yulia Sokolova-Pyatnitskaya, 1937*
- Heat as Creative Inspiration:** “Sometimes, when I play the piano, I am overcome by an inner fire, not of this world.” — *Galina Larskaya, 1987*

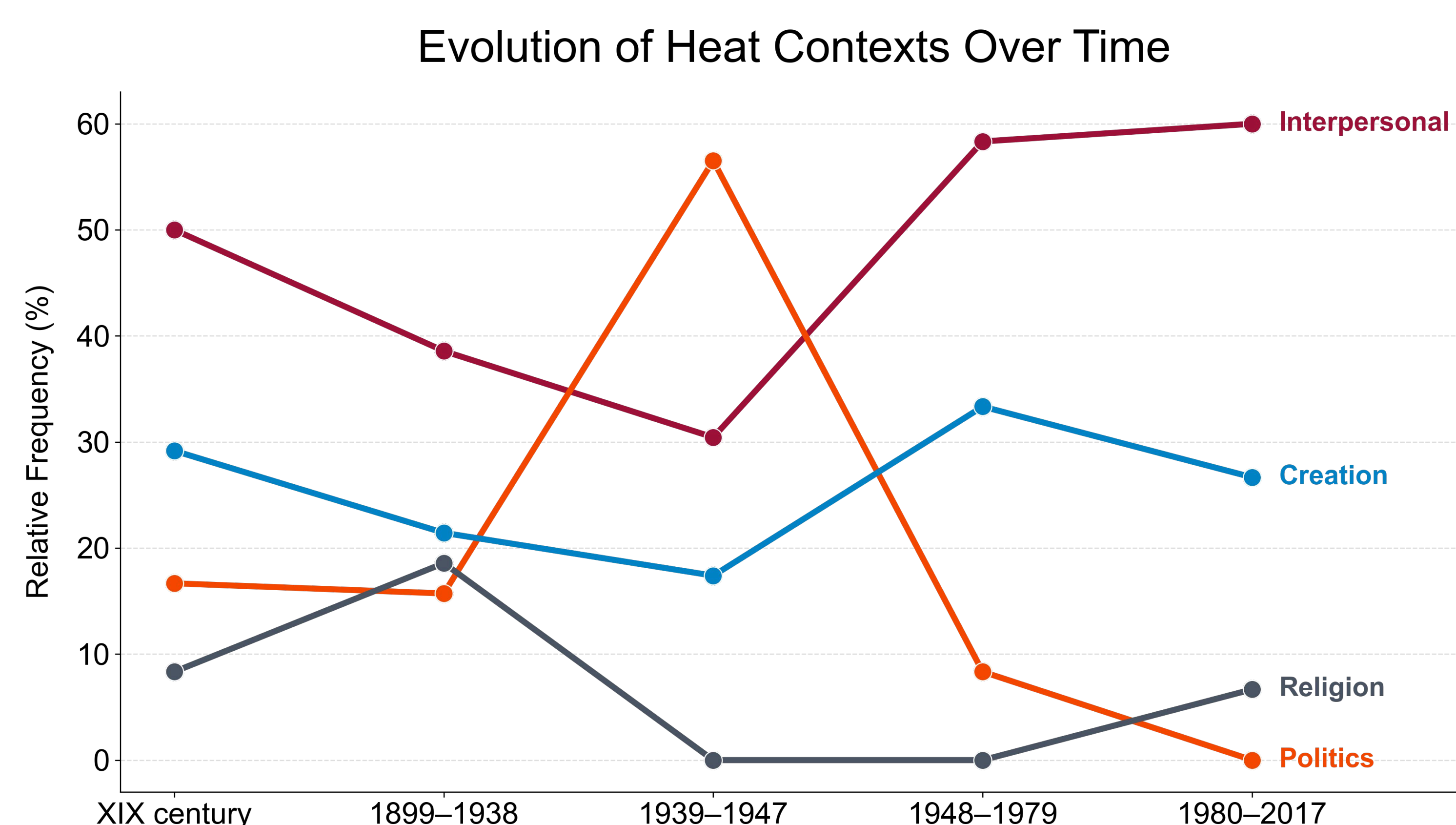


Figure 3. Relative frequency of semantic contexts over historical periods.

5. Summary

Heat emerges as a flexible image in personal writing, serving as both an imaginative metaphor for passion and a physical description of discomfort. These findings suggest historical context might influence not only what emotions diarists describe, but how they articulate them on a physical and linguistic level. Despite methodological constraints and a compact dataset, heat remains an enduring tool for processing human experience.